

Mexican revolutionaries

A Mexican rebel group, c. 1911, shoots from a boulder overlooking a desert valley filled with factories. Thousands of laborers and landless peasants fought to reclaim lost lands.



BEFORE

When the Spanish and Portuguese arrived, native Latin American cultures were to be subdued under colonial rule for 300 years.

CONQUISTADORS

The Spanish *conquistadors* (conquerors), bold and brutal adventurers, established **Spain's claim to the New World**. In 1513, Vasco Núñez de Balboa was the first European to see the Pacific. Eight years later, Hernán Cortés's Spanish expedition **conquered the**

Aztec Empire of Moctezuma

II in Mexico, and in 1532 the Spanish brought down the **Inca Kingdom** of Peru

«230–31. Mexico and Peru had rich silver and gold mines, and Mexico City became the capital of New Spain.



MOCTEZUMA HEADRESS

SPANISH AND PORTUGUESE SETTLEMENT

In the 16th century, Spanish colonists advanced north into what is now Florida and California, and south to today's Venezuela and Argentina. In the 18th century, **precious metals** and stones were discovered, and coffee cultivation began in Brazil. The Portuguese **explored Amazonia**, and formalized their claim to it in 1750.

Latin America Liberated

The people of Latin America span the entire continent of South America, Central America, Mexico, and the islands of the Caribbean. They share a history of conquest and colonization by the Spaniards and Portuguese, a struggle for liberty, and centuries of political instability.

When Napoleon turned on his Spanish allies in 1808 during the Peninsular War (see pp.304–07), events took a disastrous turn for Spain. With the Spanish king and his son Ferdinand taken hostage by Napoleon, leaders jostled for power across Spanish America and juntas filled the void. Not many lasted long, but by 1810, progress toward independence was underway.

The independence movements in South America rose from opposite ends of the continent. From the south came José de San Martín. In 1817, San Martín, a former Spanish military officer, directed 5,000 troops across the Andes from Argentina and struck at a point in Chile where loyalist forces had not been expecting an invasion. San Martín then freed the Spanish stronghold of Peru.

From the north came Simón Bolívar (see RIGHT). Bolívar's forces invaded Venezuela in 1813, waging a ferocious campaign, but the rebels achieved only short-lived victories. In 1817 a larger and revitalized movement for independence emerged, and won the struggle in the north. Bolívar was named president of Gran Colombia in 1819, a union of Venezuela, Colombia, Panama, and Ecuador. The tide had

turned in favor of independence, and by 1821 further military campaigns had liberated New Granada and Venezuela. In the central Andes, the southern and northern armies attacked in a pincer movement to crush the remaining loyalist strength, and in 1824 Peru gained its independence.

In Mexico, a unique movement emerged in 1810, led by a radical priest, Miguel Hidalgo y Costilla.



Battle of Maipú

José de San Martín led his rebel troops over the heights of the Andes to fight Spanish royalists. The Battle of Maipú, in 1818, gained Chile liberty from Spanish domination. The Spanish army was so demoralized—2,000 died and 3,000 were captured—that San Martín was also able to liberate Peru.